



CREATING A TWITTER SEARCH WIDGET WITH CATALYST

WHAT ARE FLEX AND CATALYST?

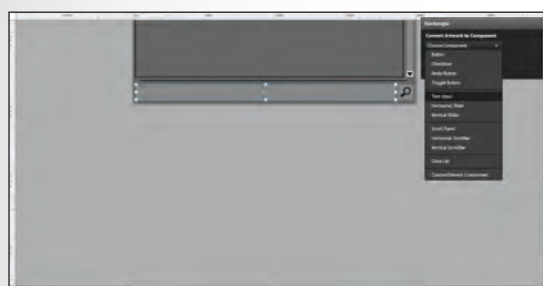
Most of you will certainly be aware of Flash, and must have certainly viewed a Flash-based website at some point; however you might be less aware of Flex. The Flex SDK allows those familiar with ActionScript – the scripting language used in Flash – to write applications which run on the web or on the desktop using AIR. Flash Catalyst allows you to create interfaces for Adobe Flex applications. In this short tutorial, we look at one of the steps to create a Twitter widget using Flash Catalyst. First, design the interface using Adobe Photoshop or Illustrator.



Using Flash Catalyst CS5

Launch Flash Catalyst CS5 and load the design you just created. You will see that Catalyst retains all the details. Now one by one, you will have to tell Catalyst what is the function of each part of your application. In our example, we have a search box at the bottom, and search button next to it. So we select the area we want to designate as a search box and in the floating dialog with “Convert Artwork to Component”, we click on “Choose Component” and select “Text Input”. What we use this text input for and how we use it is something we will define later in our application in Flash Builder.

Now we select the search button and in dialog with “Convert Artwork to Component” we set this one to “Button”. If you want, you can now double click the button to further



define how the button will behave on hover and selection. We went ahead and added a blue glow to the magnifying glass in the hover state.

Now we must do something about our scrollbar. We select all the components of the scrollbar and convert it to a “Vertical Scrollbar” component. Now the vertical scrollbar is a complicated component, with multiple sub-components. So we will need to

click on “Edit Parts” and define each element of the scrollbar. The scrollbar needs at least two parts to work: the scroll track, which is the long vertical area along which the scrolling takes place, and the thumb, which is the part of the scrollbar which moves. If you want, you can also specify an up button and a down button, as we have done. You need now worry about the implementation details, all of which will be handled automatically.

Next we come to the list of tweets. Select the vertical scrollbar, the border around the tweets and the single design of the tweet and convert them to a “Data List” component. Now, the data list component only needs one part defined in it, which is a sample item that will make up the list. We select our tweet and set it as a “Repeated Item”. We again have the opportunity to select what this list item looks like.



To learn more on coding the interface on Flash Builder 4, visit

www.thinkdigit.com/d/adobefc